On-device AI is a gamechanger for knowledge workers

Dell's **Jacinta Quah** on why AI belongs at the desk and not just in the cloud

Yashraj Verma | editor@digit.in

Dell's new lineup of AI-ready PCs and collaboration hardware is an indication of the PC maker's serious intent on making on-device AI shine through its enterprise offerings. Everything from the Dell Pro 3, Pro 5 and Pro 7 commercial PCs, the Dell Pro Precision 9 T2, T4 and T6 tower workstations, the Dell Pro Precision 7 R1 rack workstation, and a set of collaboration hardware that includes the Dell Pro 43 Plus 4K Huddle Conferencing Monitor, the UltraSharp 32 4K Monitor and the Dell Pro 7 Webcam 4K is a hint to how Dell is trying to move the AI conversation off the cloud and onto the desk.

The trend is on point, because token limits are a constant headache for business users of ChatGPT, Claude, and every other major AI service. The dream fix would be enterprise laptops and PCs that run AI models locally, with no token count to worry about. That's exactly what these newly launched Dell machines claim to offer. They're being pitched as a push towards hardware that can handle AI on-device.

In an exclusive conversation with Times Now Tech, Jacinta Quah, Vice President, Client Solutions Group, Asia Pacific, Japan & Greater China (APJC) at Dell, spoke about what "AI-ready" actually means on the ground, where intelligence should sit between cloud and device, what's holding companies back from scaling AI, and how Indian customer demands have shifted since NPUs arrived.



Jacinta Quah
Vice President, Client Solutions Group, Asia Pacific, Japan & Greater China (APJC) at Dell

AI-ready and agentic AI

We asked her to define what an AI-ready device means in practical terms. Quah explained that technically, it refers to a hybrid architecture combining a CPU and an on-board NPU – together forming what the industry calls an AI PC. The practical benefit is that AI workloads can run directly on the device rather than depending on other services.

Jacinta said, "It can run AI on the device," and for a factory floor worker without reliable connectivity, this means AI tools remain usable regardless of location. Quah said, "That really changed the ability of a knowledge worker to be productive, irrespective of the environment that they work in."

Quah mentioned that AI is a continuous evolution: AI began entirely in the cloud, then enterprises pushed to bring workloads on-premise, before organisations settled into hybrid environments. The next stage in that evolution, she said, is agentic AI.

She distinguished the earlier "chat" era of AI from agentic AI, which is built to complete entire workflows rather than individual tasks. Quah said, "It's a complete shift from completing a task to helping you with a workflow, and which means the productivity impact is going to be game-changing."

Increasing need for on-device AI in various work environments

On the question of whether AI processing should sit in the cloud or on the device, Quah identified several deciding factors.

Organisations in regulated industries, or those handling sensitive data and intellectual property, tend to keep processing local. Quah said, "You do not want every experiment to be sending out to the cloud."

Cloud infrastructure remains useful where an organisation needs scale, a capacity spike, or fast orchestration, though costs can climb quickly as usage scales. Between the two extremes sits a hybrid environment. Quah said, "It really depends on what you're working on, and the question is where should you run, and how should that be governed. Both are equally important."

She noted, "This reflects a broader pattern as organisations initially sent everything to the cloud, then encountered data privacy concerns, and are now reconsidering as agentic workloads and their associated cloud costs grow, which parts of their AI operations should move back on-premise."